

Huntington 1968 Claude Guide

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Contents

1	Central Claims	2
2	Core Case Studies	2
3	Core Works Cited	3
4	Chapter 1: Political Order and Political Decay	4
5	Chapter 4: Praetorianism and Political Decay	5
6	Chapter 5: Revolution and Political Order	6
7	Chapter 6: Reform and Political Change	7

1 Central Claims

- The central problem of developing societies is not poverty, inequality, or authoritarianism per se, but the **absence of political order**—the capacity to govern effectively and maintain stability.
- **Political institutionalization**, not economic development or democratic liberalization, is the precondition for stable political order. Institutions must develop *faster* than or commensurate with social mobilization.
- Modernization and economic development, by generating **social mobilization** (rising aspirations, urbanization, mass literacy), often *destabilize* polities when political institutions are too weak to channel expanded participation.
- The gap between **social mobilization** and **political institutionalization** produces political decay, not political development—disorder is the normal outcome of rapid modernization, not an aberration.
- Political institutions are judged by four qualities:
 - **Adaptability** (vs. rigidity): can they adjust to new challenges over time?
 - **Complexity** (vs. simplicity): do they consist of multiple, specialized subunits?
 - **Autonomy** (vs. subordination): are they independent from particular social forces?
 - **Coherence** (vs. disunity): do members share common purposes and procedures?
- Strong parties are the key institution for political order in modernizing states; without them, militaries, oligarchies, or mob rule fill the vacuum.
- **Political decay** is just as possible as political development; modernization theory was wrong to assume an inevitable progression toward stable democracy.
- The book is explicitly a critique of the “liberal” or “Whig” view that economic growth and social development automatically produce stable democracy.
- **Order is prior to liberty**: stable institutions must come before broad participation; premature mass participation without institutions breeds praetorianism and revolution.
- Two main paths lead to institutionalized order in modernizing states: **revolution** (rapid, comprehensive transformation led by a mobilizing party) and **reform** (incremental change steered by existing elites capable of co-opting challengers).

2 Core Case Studies

- **Turkey (Kemalist modernization)**: cited as an example of successful top-down institutionalization; the military and the Republican People’s Party built durable state capacity

before broadening participation.

- **Mexico (PRI system):** treated as a paradigmatic case of revolutionary institutionalization—the 1910 Revolution ultimately produced a strong, adaptable single party that channeled social mobilization.
- **Soviet Union:** presented (controversially) as a successful case of political institutionalization through a Leninist vanguard party, achieving order even if not liberty.
- **Latin American praetorian states** (Argentina, Bolivia, Ecuador, Peru, etc.): used extensively to illustrate military coups, political decay, and the oscillation between civilian and military rule when parties are weak.
- **South and Southeast Asia** (Vietnam, Burma, India): India is noted as a partial success owing to the Indian National Congress; Vietnam and Burma illustrate the tension between revolutionary and reform paths and the dangers of rural insurgency.
- **Middle East and Africa:** illustrative of praetorian tendencies and weak institutionalization post-independence.
- **United States:** used comparatively in Chapter 2 to argue that American exceptionalism (no feudal past, early mass participation) makes it a poor model for developing states; Tudor constitutional inheritance produced a uniquely “Tudor polity.”
- **China:** the Maoist revolution is analyzed as an example of a “Eastern” revolutionary pattern (rural-based, peasant-mobilizing) as opposed to the “Western” urban-centered model.

3 Core Works Cited

- **Alexis de Tocqueville**, *Democracy in America*—on the role of associations and civic institutions in channeling participation and preventing tyranny.
- **Karl Deutsch**, “Social Mobilization and Political Development” (1961, *APSR*)—the concept of social mobilization as the engine of rising political demands.
- **Seymour Martin Lipset**, *Political Man* (1960)—the modernization/democratization thesis Huntington is partly critiquing.
- **Gabriel Almond and Sidney Verba**, *The Civic Culture* (1963)—on political culture and participation, a reference point for comparing democratic stability.
- **David Apter**, *The Politics of Modernization* (1965)—rival modernization theory framework.
- **Max Weber**—on bureaucracy, legitimate authority, and institutionalization; Huntington’s concept of institutionalization is heavily Weberian.

- **Crane Brinton**, *The Anatomy of Revolution* (1938)—comparative revolutionary analysis that informs Chapter 5.
- **Leon Trotsky**—on the theory and practice of revolution; the “permanent revolution” concept is engaged in Chapter 5.
- **Mao Zedong**—writings on peasant revolution and rural strategy; central to the “Eastern” revolutionary model in Chapter 5.
- **Chalmers Johnson**, *Revolutionary Change* (1966)—on the social conditions for revolution.
- **Lucian Pye** and other SSRC Committee on Comparative Politics scholars—on political development and the “crises” of modernization (identity, legitimacy, participation, penetration, distribution).
- **Edward Shils**—on political development and the role of elites and intellectuals in new states.
- **Samuel Beer**—on British political parties and institutional adaptation; a positive model of institutionalization.
- **Barrington Moore Jr.**, *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (1966)—a contemporary reference on agrarian class structure and political paths to modernity.

4 Chapter 1: Political Order and Political Decay

- **Opening argument:** The most important political distinction among countries is not the form of government (democratic vs. authoritarian) but the *degree of government*—the presence or absence of effective political institutions.
- **Critique of liberal modernization theory:** The assumption that economic development and social modernization automatically produce stable, democratic polities is wrong; modernization often produces instability and violence.
- **Defining political institutionalization:** Institutions are stable, valued, recurring patterns of behavior. Their level is measured along four dimensions: adaptability, complexity, autonomy, and coherence.
- **Political order formula:** Political Community = $f(\text{political institutionalization} / \text{social mobilization})$. When the denominator (mobilization) outpaces the numerator (institutions), decay results.
- **Political participation and instability:** Rising participation without institutional capacity to absorb it creates instability; the sequence matters—institutions must precede or keep pace with participation.

- **Political decay defined:** Decay occurs when social mobilization and political participation expand faster than institutions can adapt. This produces corruption, violence, and coup-prone polities.
- **Corruption as symptom:** High corruption signals a gap between emerging social forces and the capacity of institutions to assimilate them; it is not primarily a cultural failing but an institutional one.
- **Role of the political party:** The party is singled out as the crucial modern political institution; without a strong, autonomous, coherent party, modernizing states cannot channel mass participation.
- **Normative stance:** Huntington is explicitly not arguing for liberal democracy as the goal; stability and order are the primary values in the book's framework.

5 Chapter 4: Praetorianism and Political Decay

- **Defining praetorianism:** A praetorian society is one in which social forces—military, clergy, students, workers, oligarchs—intervene directly in politics using their own methods rather than acting through political institutions.
- **Praetorian vs. civic polities:** In a civic polity, military, economic, and religious groups operate within and through political institutions. In a praetorian polity, each group “plays politics” directly with its own resources.
- **Low institutionalization as cause:** Praetorianism arises from weak political parties and institutions, not from the particular character of any one social force (e.g., the military). When institutions are strong, militaries stay in barracks.
- **Three types of praetorian systems** by social composition:
 - **Oligarchical praetorianism:** politics dominated by traditional elites (landowners, clergy); coups are elite affairs; characteristic of early modernization.
 - **Radical/middle-class praetorianism:** middle-class and military officers intervene to check both oligarchs and rising lower classes; reform coups are common.
 - **Mass praetorianism:** mass participation without institutional channels; populist or leftist coups, mob politics, and high instability.
- **Military as political actor:** The military's proclivity for intervention is a function of the political environment, not of its internal culture; militaries intervene when other institutions are too weak to govern.
- **Reform vs. veto coups:** Military coups in middle-class praetorian systems often have modernizing/reform goals; in mass praetorian systems they tend to be counter-revolutionary, blocking lower-class demands.

- **Limits of military rule:** Even reform-minded militaries cannot create the political party or civic institutions needed for durable order; military governments tend to be transitional or they themselves become institutionalized (Turkey, Egypt) through party-building efforts.
- **Corruption link:** Praetorian societies exhibit high corruption because there is no institutional authority capable of enforcing norms; private power replaces public rule.
- **Path out of praetorianism:** Escaping praetorianism requires building a strong, autonomous political party (or parties) that can aggregate and channel demands—neither economic development alone nor military modernization accomplishes this.

6 Chapter 5: Revolution and Political Order

- **Definition of revolution:** A rapid, fundamental, and violent transformation of a society's dominant values and myths, its political institutions, social structure, leadership, government activity, and policies—distinguished from coups, rebellions, and reform.
- **Revolution as institution-builder:** Paradoxically, revolution can *create* political order by destroying old institutions and building new, highly mobilized ones (party, army, bureaucracy) capable of incorporating mass participation.
- **Western vs. Eastern revolutionary models:**
 - **Western pattern** (France, Russia, China urban phase): urban-based, begins with collapse of the old regime, then a power struggle among competing revolutionary groups, followed by consolidation.
 - **Eastern pattern** (Maoist, Vietnamese): rural-based, the revolutionary movement builds a “counter-state” in the countryside, mobilizes peasants, then encircles and defeats the urban center.
- **Peasants as the decisive revolutionary class in Eastern pattern:** Unlike urban workers, peasants are the decisive social base in agrarian developing societies; revolutionaries who can organize the peasantry gain an overwhelming structural advantage.
- **Role of the countryside:** In Eastern revolutionary strategy, the countryside is not just a refuge but the political base; land reform and peasant organization are the political instruments that build the revolutionary party-state.
- **Conditions favoring revolution:** Weak, corrupt, or externally dependent governments; a mobilizing revolutionary organization capable of discipline and strategy; a peasantry experiencing dislocation from traditional agrarian relations.
- **Post-revolutionary institutionalization:** Successful revolutions produce strong, highly institutionalized states (Soviet Union, China, Mexico) precisely because the revolutionary process destroys competing elites and forces the construction of new mass institutions.

- **Limits of counter-insurgency:** Huntington argues (with implicit reference to Vietnam) that military suppression alone cannot defeat a well-rooted rural revolutionary movement; the political problem (weak government, absence of peasant allegiance) must be addressed.
- **Revolution and modernization:** Revolution is one route—the most violent and radical—by which a society can close the gap between social mobilization and political institutionalization; it is not an aberration but a structural possibility within modernization.

7 Chapter 6: Reform and Political Change

- **Reform defined:** Incremental, non-violent change in social, economic, or political structures initiated or guided by existing elites—distinguished from revolution by its piecemeal, controlled character.
- **Reform as the alternative to revolution:** Where political institutions are strong enough to manage change (or where elites are willing and capable of co-opting challengers), reform can close the gap between mobilization and institutionalization without violent rupture.
- **Reform requires political strength:** Counter-intuitively, successful reform is not the product of weak governments giving in to pressure; it requires strong governments capable of *choosing* to reform and then controlling the pace and scope of change.
- **The reformer's dilemma:** Reform from above must move fast enough to preempt revolutionary demands but slowly enough not to trigger a counter-revolutionary backlash from entrenched elites; timing and sequencing are everything.
- **Land reform as the test case:** Agrarian reform is the central case study for reform analysis—it is the issue most likely to determine whether modernizing societies follow a reform or revolutionary path, because land is the primary resource mobilizing peasant demands.
- **Bourgeois reform coalitions:** Successful reform often requires a coalition of urban middle class, reform-minded military, and progressive elite elements willing to sacrifice some immediate interests to preserve overall social stability.
- **“Fabian” strategy:** Huntington describes a strategy of gradual, managed reform that incorporates new social groups sequentially, preventing any single group from becoming an unmanageable revolutionary force.
- **U.S. foreign policy implications:** The chapter has explicit policy implications for American strategy in the developing world—supporting reform-capable governments is more effective than backing status-quo governments or attempting counter-revolutionary suppression.

- **Limits of reform:** Reform fails when the pace of social mobilization is too rapid for elite-managed change to keep up, when elites are too rigid to make meaningful concessions, or when a revolutionary organization has already consolidated sufficient peasant support.
- **Reform and institutionalization:** Even successful reform must ultimately produce stronger institutions—parties, legislatures, bureaucracies—capable of absorbing future demands; reform that solves immediate crises without building institutions only postpones instability.